Tabletop Game

Con-selor

Con-selor is a betting, psychological and multilateral competition game inspired by the 2019 US Admission Bribery Scandal. The game was designed to expose the 'pull strings' in US admissions, and the racial preferences universities hold towards applicants.

In this game, players may act as a college counsellor, "work on" the students they bet to meet the college's requirements and win the bonuses.

As a corporate project, I was in charge of the game design and project management, while my teammate Lixue was responsible for the visual design.

Genre
Betting, Bluffing, Hand management, Psychological competition



Corleone VII

AP = 5 | $ = 1

If Corleone VII is No.1 of the round, take the total $ (student and school) of No.2.



Paris Hiltown

AP = 1 | $ = 6

Draw an unplaced student and hide under Hiltown. Add its AP to Hiltown's settlement.



Michael Williams

AP	$
2	7



Yee Tee

AP = 0 | $ = 10

If Tee's AP ≥ 10 at settlement, who bet on Tee gets $10 while others get NONE.





Awan Navajo

AP	$
3	7



Muhammad Burhan

AP	$
6	4



Components

Student Cards x 10
School Cards x 8

Game Cards x 95
Basic Cards x 50
Magic Cards x 38
Super Cards x 7

Betting Cards x 30
(6 Sets)

Instruction Book x 1



Rule Book

Number of Players: 3-5
Approximate Time: 30-45 min
Age: 12+

Background

Dear counselors,
It's almost application season, and parents are getting worried while students are not ready yet. It is the perfect time for us to forge the next generation. Use your connections, cast a little spell on these children, take them to the next level, and make a fortune ($)!

Watch out for your competitors, think wisely and win your fortune!
Good luck!

Game Description

In this game, players are played as college counselors. They will bet on one or two students and helps them to get into college. The counselors will use the cards to "help" the students to raise their skills. If the student that counselor bet on has been accepted by the college (the student's Academic Power (AP) meets the school's requirement), the counselor will receive a total bonus ($) of the student's plus the school's $. The game consists of 3 rounds. In the end, the player with the most $ becomes the winner with the "Best Counselor in the Universe" title.

Game Accessories

Student Cards x 10
School Cards x 8
Game Cards x 95
Betting Cards x 30 (5 cards per set *6)

Instruction Book x 1

Game Cards

Basic Card (B)
Can directly increase or decrease the student's Academic Power (AP) value.

Magic Card (M)
Can strengthen, weaken or cause diverse effects to the game.

Super Card (S)
Can cause a decisive impact on the game, and their effects cannot be cancelled by any Magic Cards during settlement.

Categories

Open Card
Use with the functional side up.

Hidden Card
Use with the functional side down.

Instant Card
Use with the functional side up. Trigger its effect immediately and discard it right after use.

Recycle Card
Cards with the recycle sign can discard to exchange for a new card from the pile.

School Card
Each school has different requirements for admission ranking and offers different amounts of bonuses ($). If the counselor bets on the right student, he/she will receive a total bonus ($) of the student's plus the school's $. In the event of a tie, the admission priority will according to the established racial preferences (see settlement stage).



Student Card
Each student has a different Academic Power (AP) value and a bonus ($) value. Special students: Corleone VII, Paris Hiltown and Yee Tee have special scoring conditions.



Betting Card
Betting cards are used to bet on the students that counselors wish to get into schools.



Game Flow

Each game has 3 rounds, and each round contains 5 stages: Preparation Stage, Betting Stage, Playing Stage, Settlement Stage and Ending Stage. Shuffle all cards before the game starts, and reshuffle the used cards whenever the game card deck is used.

Preparation Stage

1. Each counselor receives a set of Betting cards (1 to 5) corresponding to the 5 students on the field.

2. Draw 3 School cards and display them on the table. The order in which they are drawn is the university's admission sequence in the game.

3. In each round, counselors draw a set number of Game cards from the deck corresponding to the table below.

Number of Counselors	Round 1	Round 2	Round 3
3 Counselors	6 cards	5 cards	5 cards
4 Counselors	6 cards	4 cards	4 cards
5 Counselors	5 cards	4 cards	4 cards



Get a set of Betting cards (1 to 5) | Draw and Display 3 School Cards | Draw Game cards (Set numbers)

4. In each round, draw 5 student cards and display them in 1 to 5 order (pair up with betting cards).

Betting Stage

Counselors may bet on 1 to 2 students with their betting cards. Numbers on the betting card represent a corresponding student displayed. Place the chosen betting cards face down, and hide the rest of the betting cards on the side.

Single bet
If a counselor only bets on 1 student and successfully meets the school's requirement in this round's settlement, the counselor receives the school's bonus ($) and the DOUBLED student bonus $.



Bets on 1 student (accepted) | Receive DOUBLED bonus from student

Double bet
If a counselor bets on 2 students and 1 of them successfully meets the school's requirement in this round's settlement, the counselor receives the total bonus ($) from the student and the school's $. If both students are accepted, the counselor receives bonuses ($) from BOTH students and schools.



Bets on 2 students (both accepted) Receive bonus from both students

After everyone has made their bet, move to the next stage.

Playing Stage

Determine the starter
The starter can be determined by any rules (e.g. the youngest, spinning the pen), and the turning order could be clockwise or counter-clockwise, decided by the starter.
*From the second round onwards, whoever with the most $ should be the starting player.

Place cards
Counselors should use game cards strictly based on their categories (Open, Hidden, or Instant). Game cards should be placed beneath any student cards in sequence.
*Each counselor must use only 1 card per turn, "Cancel" uses as Instant cards does not occupy a player's turn.
*Recycling a card is equivalent to using a card. This action occupies a turn.

The "2 for 1" method
According to the formulated card nature of the ability deck, counselors may use the "2 for 1" method indefinitely: discard two cards unrevealed to the discard pile for 1 new card from the deck. No more cards should be played after "2 for 1" until the next turn.

Claim "PASS"
Counselors should claim "PASS" in their turn if no more cards need to be played and discard their game cards to ≤ 4. No more actions should be involved from the one who passed. After everyone has passed, move to the settlement stage.

Settlement Stage

Card Effects
The settlement starts in sequence from the first to the fifth student and settles the card effects in the following order:
1. "Boom Up"(B) and "Boom Down"(B).
2. "Always No.2"(S) and "Fresh Blood"(S).

3. "Cancel"(M) played as hidden cards.
4. The rest cards settle from top to bottom of the column.

Admission
After the card effects have been settled, rank the AP value of students and decide on the admission list based on the school's requirements. *If Yee Tee reaches its special victory condition, ONLY Tee wins.

Bonus($)
If counselors bet on the accepted student(s), they should:
1. Find out how many of their betted students have been accepted(1 or 2).
2. Count their total bonus ($) from each admission (the student adds the school's $).
3. Double the student bonus ($) if they only bet for 1 student (see betting stage rule).

Tie and Preference
If a tie in AP value happens, the preference order of all admission is Michael Williams > Eesha Kashmir > Mariana Garcia > Muhammad Burhan > John Wright > Yangyang Hu > Paris Hiltown > Corleone VII.
*Yee Tee is excluded from any admission ranking.

Ending Stage

When the settlement is finished, reshuffle all student cards and clear the used game cards to the discard pile. Return to the preparation stage 3. for the next round.

End of Game

The game ends after 3 rounds, and the counselor with the most bonus ($) wins. If two or more players have the equal highest bonus($), the game ends in a tie.

Student Cards (10)			
Name	AP	$	
Yangyang Hu	6	5	
John Wright	7	4	
Muhammad Burhan	6	4	
Eesha Kashmir	5	5	
Michael Williams	2	7	
Mariana Garcia	3	6	
Awan Navajo	3	7	
Name	AP	$	Special Skill
Corleone VII	5	1	If Corleone is No.1 of the round, take the total $ (student and school) of No.2. * If counselors single bet on Corleone and he is No.1 of the round, ONLY his original $ is doubled, not No.2's. *Corleone only takes the original total $ of No.2, the type of bet others made on NO.2 does not affect bonus settlement. E.g., Corleone VII is No.1 of Standfart University (single bet by Counselor A) and Yangyang Hu is No.2 (single bet by Counselor B). In the settlement, Counselor A gains: Corleone VII's double $ (single bet) + Standfart's No.1 $ + Yangyang Hu's $ + Standfart's No.2 $ =2+5+3+3 =$11 *Counselor B's type of bet (single bet) on Yangyang Hu does not affect the bonus $ value Corleone takes from No.2.

Paris Hiltown	1	6	Draw an unplaced student and hide under Hiltown. Add its AP to Hiltown's settlement. *The unplaced student should be drawn from the rest of the student pile, not picked. Must not peek or reveal the hidden student until settlement. *Show the student and add his/her AP value to Hiltown's original AP value for settlement. E.g., An unplaced "Student X" is drawn and placed under Hiltown. In the settlement, counselors find "Student X" is Yangyang Hu. Hiltown's original AP should be: Hiltown's AP + Yangyang Hu's AP =1+8
Yee Tee	0	10	If Tee's AP ≥ 10 at settlement, who bet on Tee gets $10 while others get NONE. *Tee is excluded from and holds no position in any admission ranking; Tee cannot be accepted by ANY school. * If Tee achieves its exceptional victory condition (AP ≥ 10 at settlement), counselors only receive Tee's original bonus ($) without the school's bonus and those without betting Tee receive NONE. *If Tee fails, skip Tee when setting the AP ranking of other students. E.g., At settlement, Tee's AP=8 which fails to achieve its exceptional victory condition. Yangyang Hu has highest AP of 10 while John Wright's is third highest AP of 5. The order of the admission rank in this round should be: Rank 1: Yangyang Hu (AP=10) Rank 2: John Wright (AP=5)

School Cards (8)				
Name	No.1 Requirement	$	No.2 Requirement	$
Can-Bridge University	Rank 1 in AP	5	Rank 1 in AP	2
Standfart University	Rank 1 in AP	3	Rank 1 in AP	3
Wall Street College	Rank 1 in AP	3	Rank 1 in AP	1
Yell University	Rank 1 in AP	4	Rank 1 in AP	1
School of Lase	Rank 1 in AP	0	Rank 1 in AP	6
Human Research Center	Rank 1 in AP	3	Rank 5 in AP	2
Juvenile Reform College	Rank 5 in AP	2	Rank 4 in AP	1

Name	No.1 Requirement	$	No.2 Requirement	$	No.3 Requirement	$
Wild Goose University	Rank 1 in AP	4	Rank 2 in AP	2	Rank 3 in AP	0

Basic Cards (80)					
Category	Function	Number of cards	Category	Function	Number of cards
	+3	4		+2	2
	+4	4		+3	2
	+5	2		+4	2
	+8	2		-2	2
	+12	1		-3	2
	-3	4		-4	2
	-4	4		+2	2
	-6	2		+3	2
	-8	2		+4	2
	-12	1		-2	2
				-3	2
				-4	2

Magic Cards (38)			
Category	Name	Number of cards	Function
	Steal	2	Grab a card from your counselor of choice. "Steal" can be used for passed counselors. *Passed counselors can use "Cancel" to cancel its effect.
	Sneak Peek (To all)	3	Flip over the row where the card is placed. Get a card instantly after used. *The row remains open in this round.
	Sneak Peek (Yourself only)	3	Flip over the column where the card is placed and peek at the information yourself only. Place the column back to its original order.
	Cross Peek (To all)	1	Place this card anywhere and flip over all adjacent cards (up, down, left and right). Get a card instantly after used. *The adjacent cards remain open in this round.
	Cross Peek (Yourself only)	1	Place this card anywhere and flip over all adjacent cards (up, down, left and right) and peek at the information yourself only. Place the adjacent cards back to its original order.
	Harvest Time	2	Show the amount of cards from the deck equaling to the number of counselors. Each one pick a card in *the conventional turning order (starts from you).
	Target Blast	2	Remove a placed game card of choice.
	Row Bomb	3	Remove the entire row unrevealed where you placed the bomb.
	Happy Hour	2	Get 2 game cards from the top of the deck.
	Exchange (With left)	2	Exchange position of a placed game card and its left adjacent card.
	Exchange (With right)	2	Exchange position of a placed game card and its right adjacent card.
	Exchange (Left and right)	2	Choose a placed game card, exchange position of its left and right adjacent card.
	Double	3	Double all B cards' value that is placed above.
	Swap	3	Switch the original AP and $ value of the student.
	Cancel	6	As Instant: cancel the Instant cards' effect; As Hidden: cancel effects of all M cards placed above. *Can be canceled by another "Cancel". **"Cancel" used as an Instant Card does not occupy a player's turn.

Super Cards (7)			
Category	Name	Number of cards	Function
	Bomb Down	2	Remove the adjacent card placed below the bomb.
	Bomb Up	2	Remove the adjacent card placed above the bomb.
	Always No.2	1	The student automatically becomes No.2.
	Fresh Blood	1	Draw an unplayed student and replace the former student.
	Twist	1	Reverse the plus/minus sign of B cards in the column.

Core Mechanics



Betting

The betting choice each player makes before the start of the game affects the tactics and the use of game cards. By revealing the betting choice of each player at the end of the round, players experience sudden excitement by knowing others' scoring in the competition.



Hand Management

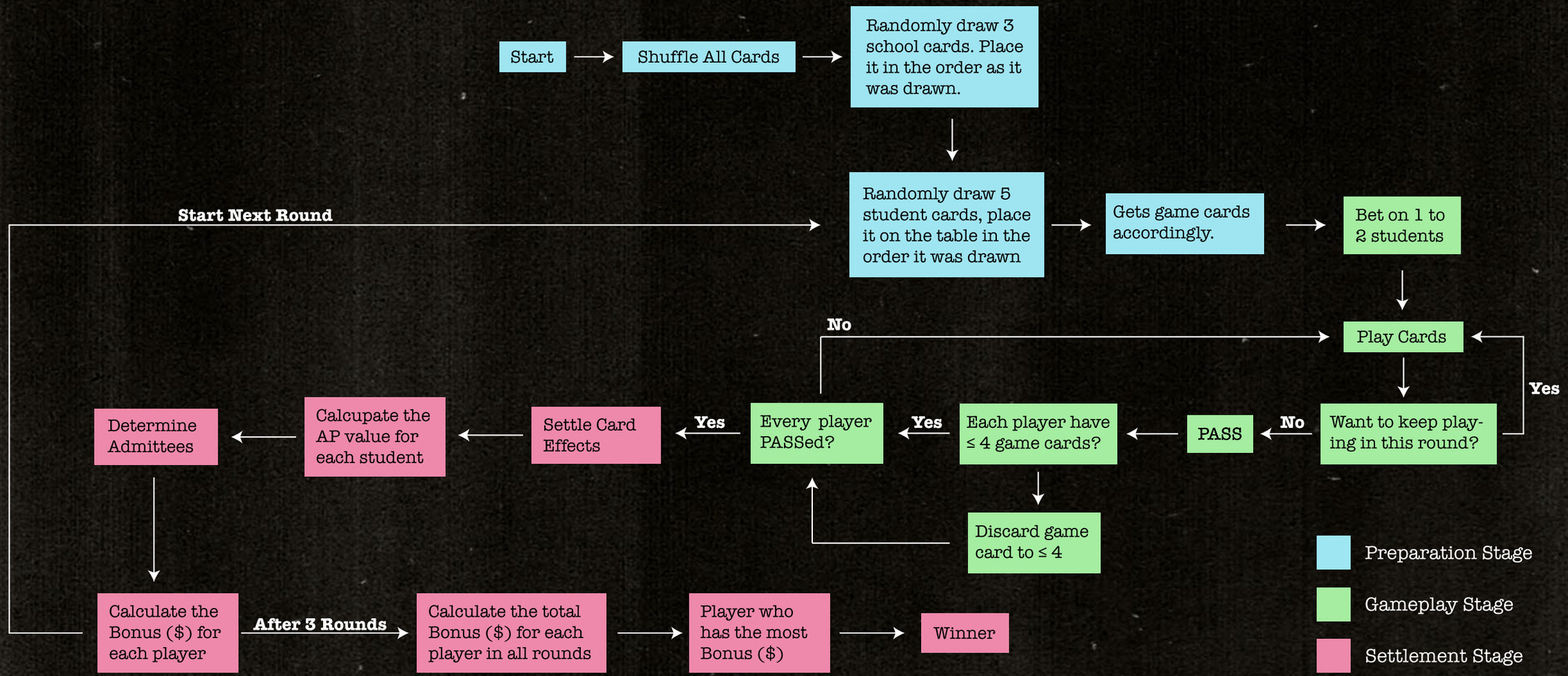
The player will affect the student's AP by placing game cards below that student, and the placement under each student will be different and unique, eventually affecting the result. Using the game cards wisely in a game leads the player to their final success.



Take That

Some game cards the player receives include the chances of taking another player's card or receiving new cards. The chance of receiving or losing cards creates massive changes in the player's future tactics and position of power in the game.

Game Flow


Start
Shuffle All Cards
Randomly draw 3 school cards. Place it in the order as it was drawn.
Randomly draw 5 student cards, place it on the table in the order it was drawn
Gets game cards accordingly.
Bet on 1 to 2 students
Play Cards
Want to keep playing in this round?
Yes
No
PASS
Each player have ≤ 4 game cards?
Yes
Discard game card to ≤ 4
Every player PASSed?
Yes
No
Settle Card Effects
Calcupate the AP value for each student
Determine Admittees
Start Next Round
Calculate the Bonus ($) for each player
After 3 Rounds
Calculate the total Bonus ($) for each player in all rounds
Player who has the most Bonus ($)
Winner
Preparation Stage
Gameplay Stage
Settlement Stage

Inspiration

US Admission Bribery Scandal

In March 2019, The United States announced one of the **largest college admissions bribery** cases involving well-known actors, CEOs, and a number of athletic coaches from Yale, Stanford, Georgetown, USC, UCLA and other well-known colleges.

These cases were done by a so-called "Independent application consultant", William Rick Singer, who ran a nonprofit organization called the Key Worldwide Foundation. Under the guise of this organization, he secretly bribed students to get into top schools and earned a total of **$25 million** from 2011 to 2018 (Archive and feed).



Applying illegal approaches such as **replacing test papers, bribing SAT examiners, faking athletic prowess, and bribing college coaches to recommend assigned students to universities,** etc., Singer helped children of rich people and celebrities to take unfair advantages in college admission.

For instance, Singer helped the daughter of a famous Hollywood actress raise her SAT scores by bribing examiners to get questions and answers in advance, providing false evidence of having dyslexia to double her exam time. Through Singer's tactics, she scored 1420 on the SAT, 400 points higher than her score on the PSAT (Nast). Moreover, Singer paid $400,000 to Yale women's soccer coach Rudy Meredith to disguise students as the Yale preferred 'athletic type' to increase their chances of acceptance (Gallagher et al.). After being accepted by the university, students skipped training by pretending to be injured.

When this illegal practice was exposed, all parents involved were punished accordingly, and Singer was sentenced to **six months in prison** and two years of supervised release for racketeering, money laundering, and deception (McLaughlin).

As a student about to apply to college, I feel angry about Singer's scandal as it undermined the fairness of admission and disgraced the efforts other students made in their studies. Therefore, this scandal inspired me to create this tabletop game - **'Con-selor'**.





Research

The admission standard in US universities tends to give a boost towards certain racists to diversify their student body and create a multicultural community that is more reflective of the United States as a whole.

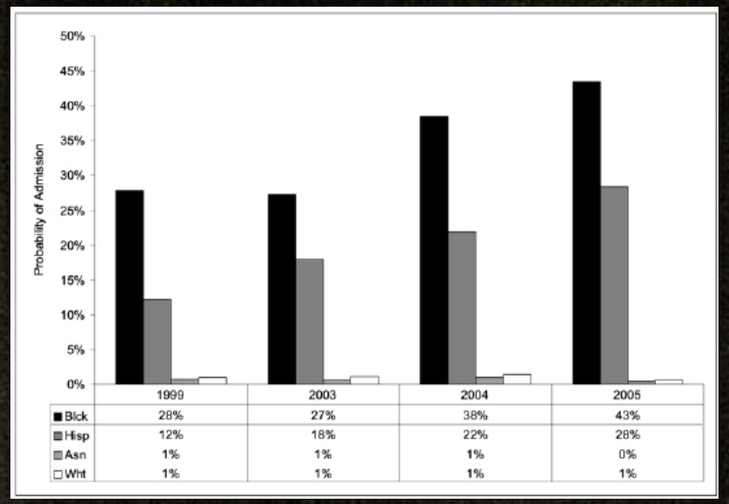


Figure 3. Probability of Admission

Figure 3 presents the probability of admission of all male Chicago Residents for each race with no legacies and other connections with the school. The data were adjusted to have the same GPA and SAT. As shown in the figure, blacks have the highest probability of acceptance rate at 43% in 2005, while Asians experienced 0%. Collecting the GPA and SAT scores of each admittee and group by race shows that blacks would receive a lower boundary of entering the school than other races.

As shown in Figures 4 and 5, among all the students admitted to the University of Chicago, African Americans have the lowest score in both SAT and GPA, while Asians and White have the highest score. According to Dr Althea Nagai, a senior researcher from the Center for Equal Opportunity, the figures for students with higher SAT scores and lower high school GPAs are perhaps even more dramatic. Blacks and Hispanics in 2005 with the same background described above but a 1240 SAT and 3.2 GPA had roughly a nine in ten chance of admissions (92 and 88 percent, respectively); Asians and whites with the same background and credentials, on the other hand, had only about a one in ten chance (10 and 14 percent, respectively).

Thus, it can be concluded that admission standards of US universities tend to show a high tendency towards certain races. This information was implemented at the settlement stage.

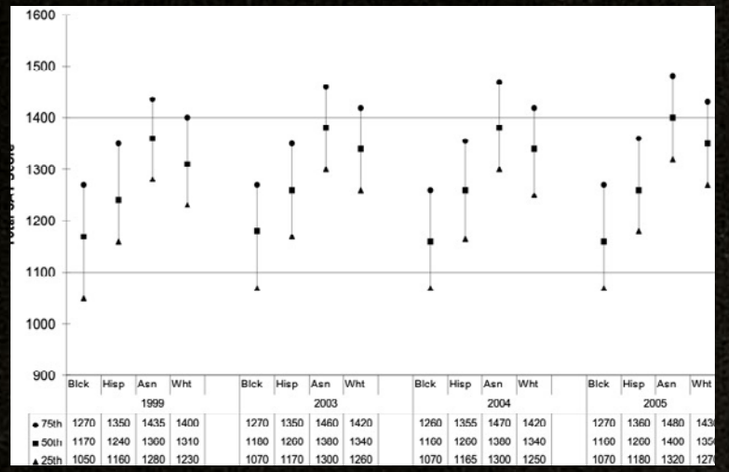


Figure 4. Total SAT scores for admittees

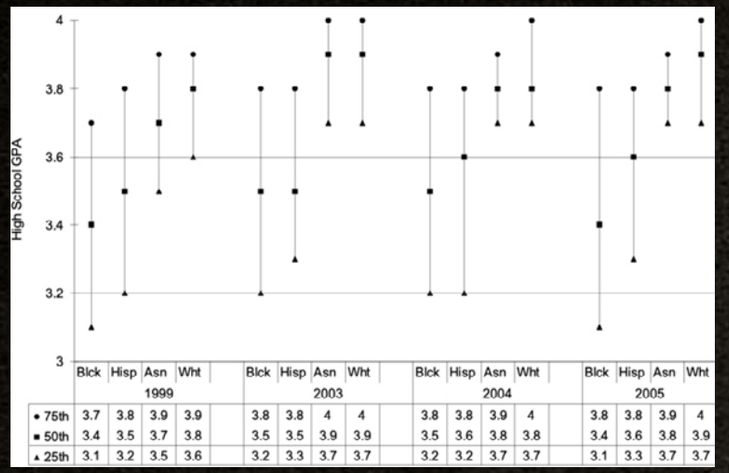


Figure 5. High school GPA for admittees

Game Inspiration

Texas Hold'em

One of the great pleasures of Texas Hold'em is betting at the beginning of the game, where we need to guess the component's size of cards while also how to conceal their true intentions. Through that, I experienced the fun of psychological competition. Therefore, I introduced the betting mechanic used in Texas Hold'em into my game: players would experience excitement and joy through betting, guessing and probing during the gameplay.



Crazy Arcade

Crazy Arcade is a team confrontation game that played as a child where players place water balls and try to bomb other players and stay alive till the end of the game. I introduced similar concepts from Crazy Arcade to my game: "row/column bomb". Using "row/column bomb", players can eliminate other card's function.





Cheaty Mages!

Cheaty Mages! is also a psychological competition game and the primary reference of my initial game prototype. My game flow and mechanisms are based on the Cheat Mages!. Based on its foundation, I improved and introduced new mechanisms to enhance the interactions between players and create diverse and high randomness to provide more exciting gameplay.

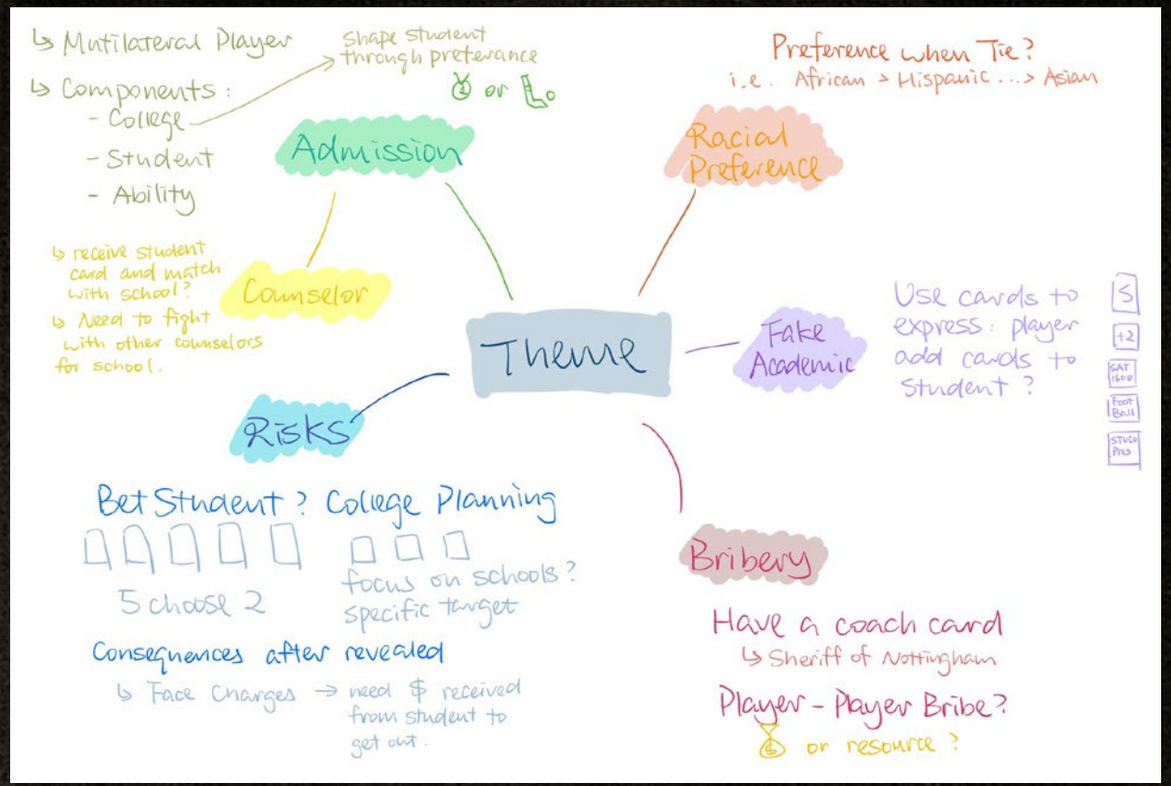


Legends of the Three Kingdoms

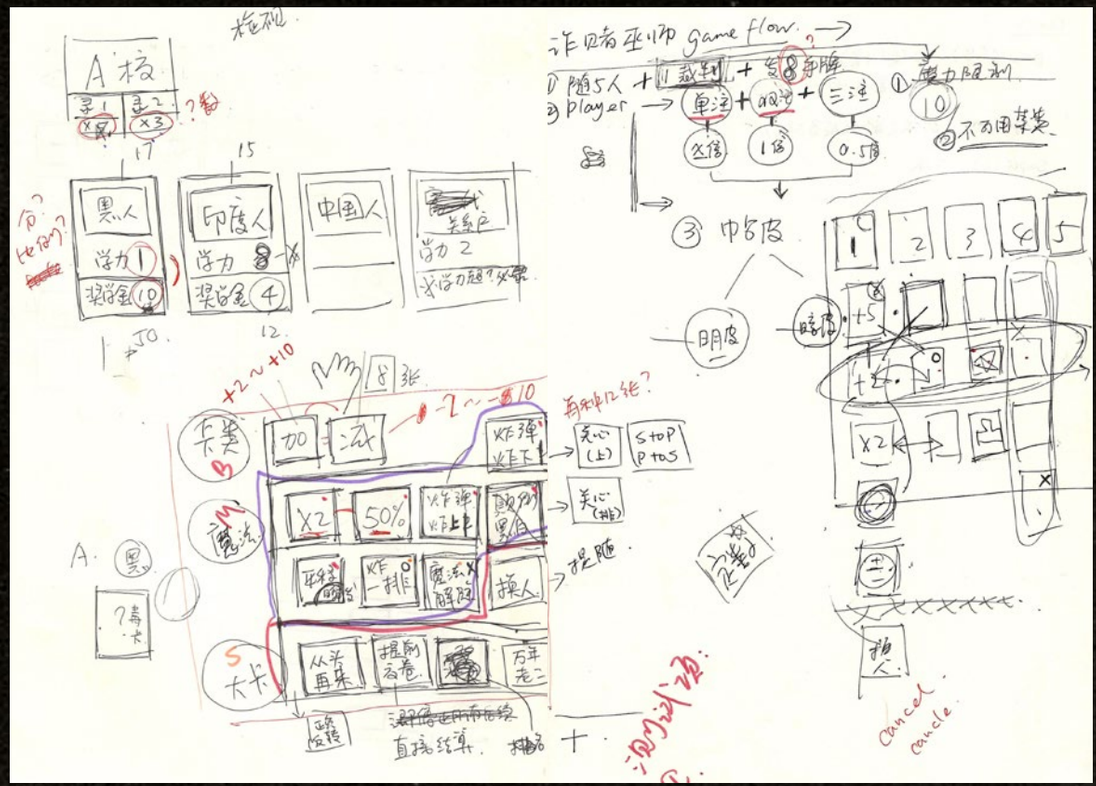
This is a popular card-based team matching game in China with many awesome functional card designs, with frequent interaction between players and mutual constraints between teams when playing this game. I involved similar card designs in increasing the approaches of creating card differences among players.

Brainstorm

Based on the theme of unfair admission, we brainstormed what mechanics could be used in the game to create an immersive experience for the player that implies the actions done under the table. After brainstorming, we've decided to use betting and asymmetric information as our stepping stones as they present the best correlation with the theme.



Theme & Mechanics Brainstorm Process



Gameplay Brainstorm Process

First Prototype

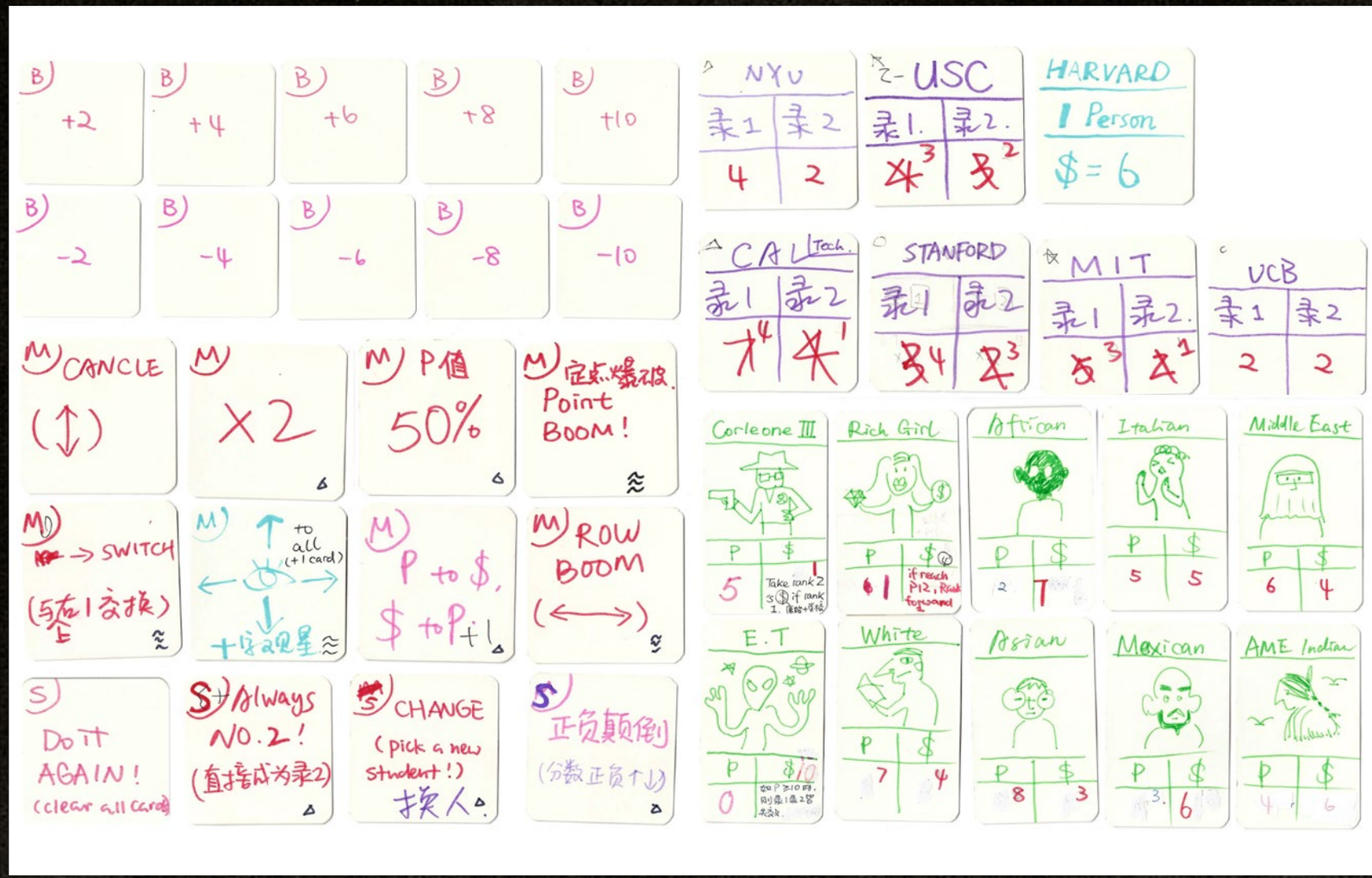
The game contains three rounds, where there will be a different school and student cards presented each round. Players will bet on one to two students, and by playing their game cards wisely to affect students' AP value, strive for admission and receive $. The player with the most $ at the end of the game will be the winner.

There are 3 cards: School Cards, Student Cards and Game Cards.

School Cards: Accept the 2 students with the highest P value, giving out a different amount of $ (based on which school).

Student Cards: Contains normal students and special students. Everyone has different AP and $ values. Special students have some unique victory conditions to gain more $, but also contain higher risks of failing.

Game Cards(B/M/S): Contains Basic, Magic and Super Cards. The Basic cards can directly increase or decrease the student's AP value. The Magic cards can strengthen, weaken or cause diverse effects to the round, and the Super Cards have even stronger effects that may sometimes turn the tables.



Iteration V1

Observation

Player: 3
Duration: 35 minutes
Cards:
- 58 game cards (B+M+S)
- 10 student cards
- 7 school cards

Problem 1. Low interaction: During the game, everyone is silently and blindly putting cards, with the lack of information on cards causing a lack of interaction between players.

Solution 1. Add Magic Cards "Steal" and "Harvest Time" from the game 'Legends of the Three Kingdoms: "Steal" enables players to take a card from a player and keep it for themselves, while "Harvest Time" can give all players a new card, presenting more player-to-player interaction while also gives the player a chance to get new cards.

Problem 2. Cannot withdraw cards: players can only stick with eight cards each round. Even if they are unsatisfied with the cards' content, they do not have a way to change their cards. Therefore, players are often in a state where they have many cards but don't want to place any.

Solution 2.(1) Add Magic Card "Happy Hour" from the game 'Legends of the Three Kingdoms: This card enables players to draw 3 cards from the card deck.

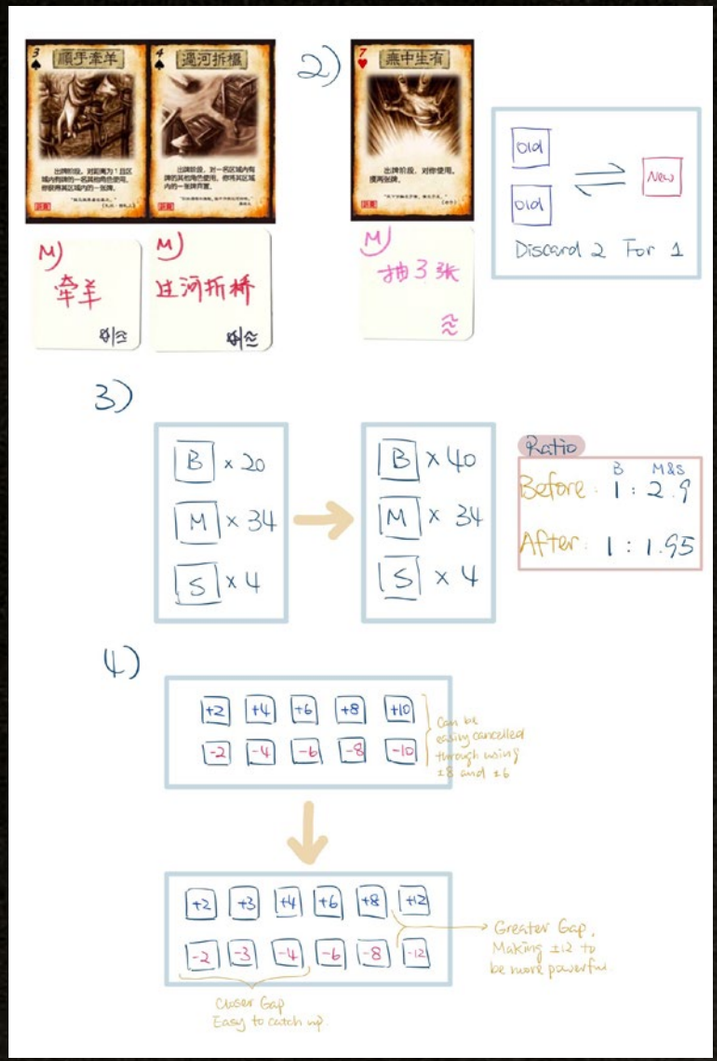
(2) Add "discard 2 for 1": Players can discard two game cards and redraw one card from the deck.

Problem 3. Odd B/M Card Ratio: the odd ratio between Basic and Magic cards led to the situation that the Basic cards could not be drawn, and players could not affect the AP of students much.

Solution 3. S The number of Basic cards has increased from 20 to 40, which is more than half of the game cards deck.

Problem 4. Distribution of B cards: The range of B cards is not wide enough, causing other B cards can quickly cancel the B cards; they have no strong cards that will affect the game.

Solution 4. Reference from "Cheaty Mages!": Based on the "Cheaty Mages!" distribution, I changed the ± 10 cards to ± 8 to make the ±12 cards more influential.



Iteration V2

Observation

Player: 4
Duration: 55 minutes
Cards:
- 78 game cards (B+M+S)
- 10 student cards
- 7 school cards

Problem 1. Unbalanced Special Student Card: In the game, we found that the Paris Hiltown feature (if the AP value reaches 12, then the rank would move forward) isn't as popular as other special students, and it is difficult for players to understand the special skill.

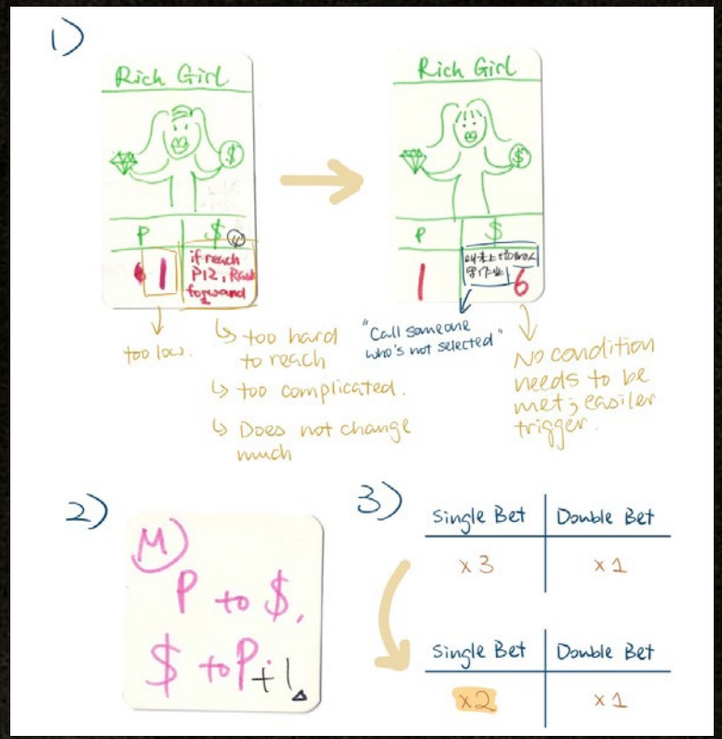
Solution 1. Change Paris Hiltown's function to "ghostwriting": Draw an unplaced student and hide under Hiltown. Add its AP to Hiltown's settlement. The unplaced student card should not be revealed or peaked when drawn.

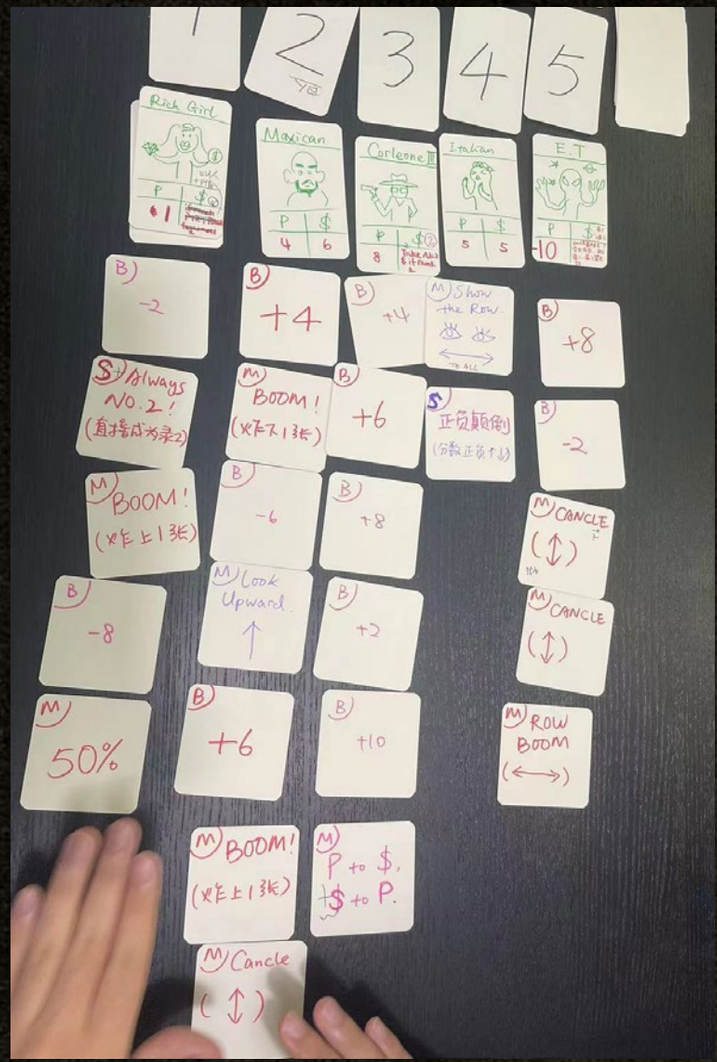
Problem 2. Lack of cards that affect students' $ value.

Solution 2. Add "Swap": This card swaps the AP and $ values on a student's card.

Problem 3. The payoff for single bets on students is too large: the payoff for single bets is tripled, causing it hard for other students to turn the table.

Solution 3. Double the payoff if single bet: remain the high-risk and reward and narrows the $ difference among players.





Iteration V3

Observation

Player: 4
Duration: 60 minutes
Cards:
- 83 game cards (B+M+S)
- 10 student cards
- 8 school cards

Problem 1. Information is too opaque: Since all cards are hidden, it is hard for players to judge other players' intentions, making the game process too random and blind with no strategy contained.

Solution 1.(1) Differentiate the cards by "open cards" and "hidden cards". Open cards are played functional side down to express some information in the round and enable the players not to forget their previous actions. Hidden cards are played with the functional side down, providing room for speculation and hiding the player's intentions.

(2). Add "Sneak Peak" cards: The "Sneak Peak" series allows the players to flip over the cards and see the function of each card to receive more information.

Problem 2. Unclear settlement process: The settlement order of M&S cards is not clear, which leads to confusion.

Solution 2.(1) Adding Instant card category: This card function will be triggered immediately and remove the card after use to reduce the complex settlement.

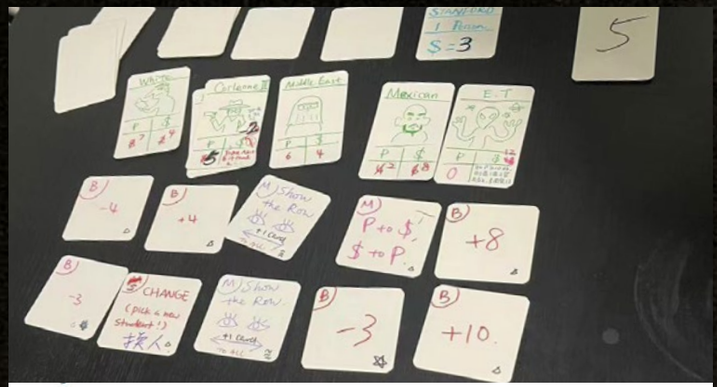
(2) Standardized the order of settlement:
The rules are set detailed to settle "Boom Up" (S), "Boom Down" (S), "Always No.2" (S), and "Fresh Blood" (S) first, then "Cancel" cards, and so on.

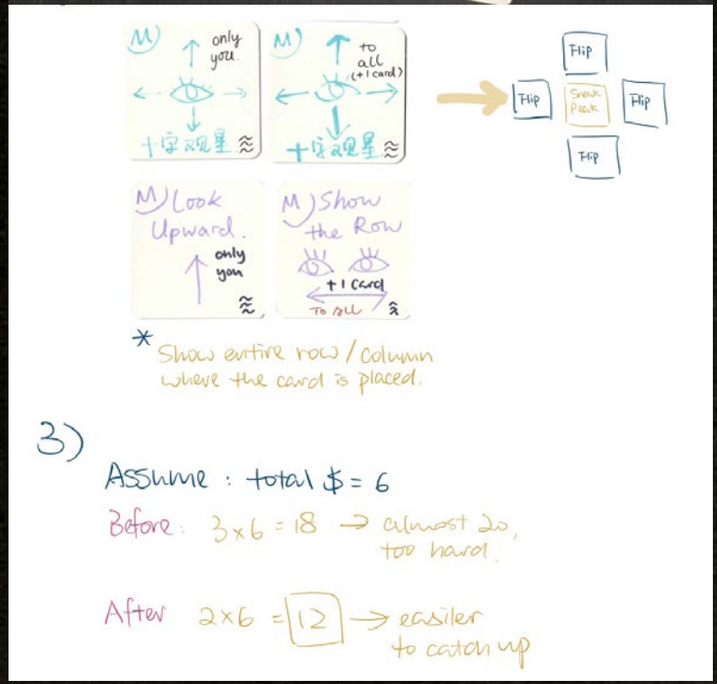
Problem 3. Excessive difference in the score: The $ value of the student cards is multiplied by the $ value of the school's $. The multiplication leads to a significant difference between players, which makes it challenging to catch up and have a bad game experience.

Solution 3. Changed multiplication to addition: Reduces the calculation difficulties and enables students to catch up in upcoming rounds.



Added Category Open, Hidden and Istant





Iteration V4

Observation

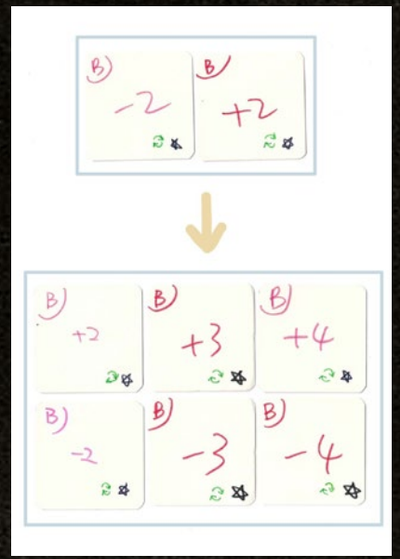
Player: 4
Duration: 60 minutes
Cards:
- 83 game cards (B+M+S)
- 10 student cards
- 8 school cards

Our previous iterations reflected that the possibility of redrawing the card is still too low. Therefore, we designed a new category: Recycle. Cards recycled can be played as open cards, and the players can also discard them and get a new one. We set it on to give the players more chances to receive new cards.

Problem 1. After a few more playtest, it is shown that every player will recycle the card, which losses the original idea of ±2 where it is used to create a false appearance and obfuscate the player's purpose.

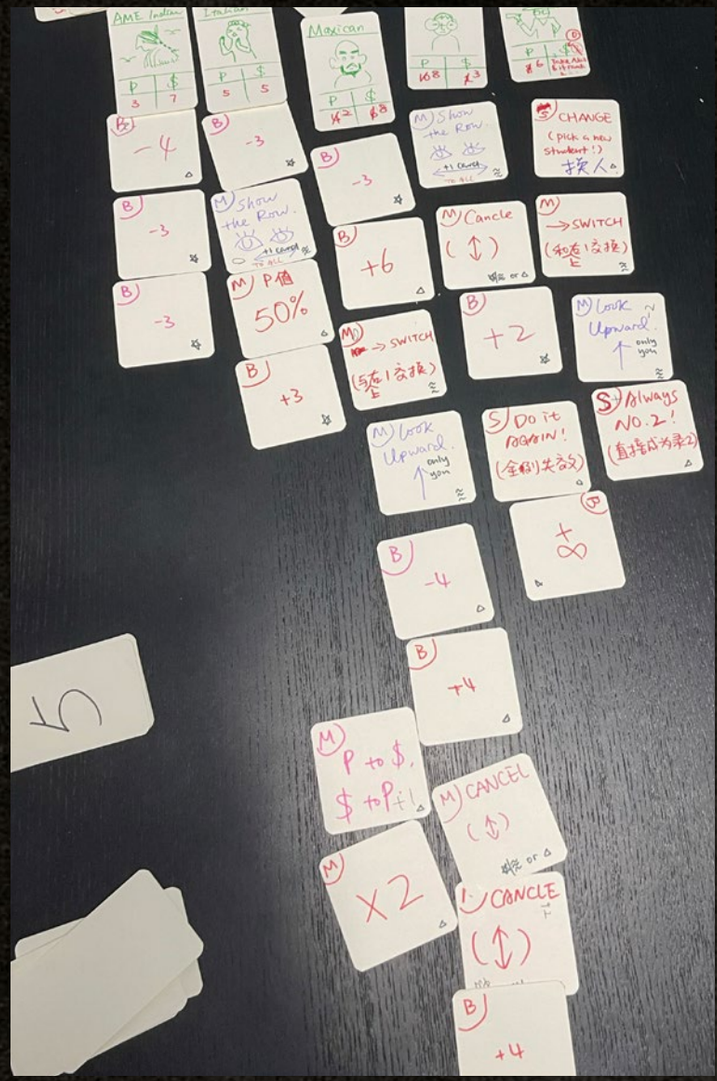
Solution 1.(1) We think the reason for this situation is that the value is too small. Therefore, the players would not use it for adding/subtracting students' AP since they do not think this card would create a significant effect. Consequently, we spread the recycle category to ±3 cards and ±4 to generate more entanglement for the players when making decisions.

(2) Moreover, a new rule was created when playing cards. Previously the rule was that each turn, the player must place a card under a student, but now it changed to one player who can only use one card per turn. Therefore, if the player decides to recycle the card, they lose the chance of adding/subtracting points for the student card. Doing so diminishes the card placed on the table, while the players must carefully decide what card to use.



The modification of Recycle cards

From +2 -2 to +2 +3 +4 & -2 -3 -4



Iteration V5

In previous iterations, the rules towards card distribution are that players will start with 8 cards in each round. However, with increased players, the card played expansions, causing an inefficient placing of cards, and the time taken is longer than expected. Therefore, a new card distribution rule was created: the card distributed to the players will be fixed in each round based on the number of players (specific card distribution see in Figure.1). By doing so, the time used for each round will be around the same for all numbers of players, while also makes the player plan the strategy used in each round ahead of the game.

Player: 3&4
Duration: 60 minutes
Reflection: 3&4 players' round was not affected by the change of the card distribution since the card change among 3&4 players is relatively small. However, it was shown that after changing the rule to "one card per turn", players would consider each turn more carefully to decide which card to use, enhancing the game's strategy.

Player: 5
Duration: 70 minutes
Problem. The players reflected that the limited of cards creates strong afflict in rounds 2&3 since the card distributed in rounds 2&3 are too few. They mentioned that the 3 cards provided could not allow them to reverse the current circumstance and score higher points.

Solution. When considering this question, we realized the cause of this situation is that when designing this rule, we were focusing on how to ensure the card used in each round are equal in all 3,4 and 5 players but neglected the fact that this action would cause the players to have fewer cards distributed, thus leading to a hard time playing. Therefore, we slightly changed the card distribution in each round again and finally received positive feedback.







Numerical Calulations

Numerical Balance

One of the obstacles when designing the game is to balance the numerical values. To ensure the balance of the values while keeping the psychological competition and high randomness components, iterations based on the ratio of Basic and Magic Cards, the categories of Student and School Cards, and the relationship between Student and School cards were conducted multiple times to reach the most balanced status.

Normal Students

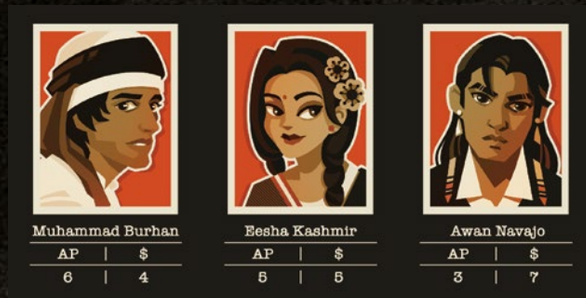
Among all ten students, I separated them into High, Medium, and Low levels based on the sum of each student's AP + $ Value. Including students with different levels will create diverse card categories that would not confuse the player. Meanwhile, by having sorts of cards, the Student cards can also form "partners" with the school cards with different requirements, providing more fun and enabling the players to create pertinence tactics, enhancing the strategy used in the game.

Student Name	AP	$	Sum	Level
Yangyang Hu	8	3	11	High
John Wright	7	4	11	High
Muhammad Burhan	6	4	10	Medium
Eesha Kashmir	5	5	10	Medium
Awan Navajo	3	7	10	Medium
Mariana García	3	6	9	Low
Michael Williams	2	7	9	Low

High
Sum = 11



Medium
Sum = 10



Low
Sum = 9



Numerical Calulations

Special Students

Special students are designed to diversify student card and game experience. We designed 3 special students with unique abilities of high risks and rewards. Some efforts are made to develop exciting skills while balancing their ratios with the regular student cards.

Yee Tee

Tee is a character that has exceptionally high risk and reward. She is perfect for counsellors with a score advantage to maintain a leading position while limiting everyone's score.

Setting the $ value to 10 creates attractiveness for players to bet on this card while warning players who did not bet on this card that the card is dangerous and players should be careful.

Corleone VII

Corleone VII's $ if Rank 1:
To find the average $ Corleone receives if he's No.1, the average $ received from a regular student will be calculated to represent the average he will take from No.2:

Average Rank 1 $:
(5+3+3+4+0+3+2+2)/2 = $3
3+2.25+5.142+1 = $11.392
Corleone VII's $ if Rank 2:
Add the average Rank 2 $ and Corleone VII's original $ value,

Average Rank 2 $:
(2+3+1+1+6+2+1+1)/2 = $2.25

1+2.25 = $3.25

Normal Student Average $:
(3+4+4+5+6+7+7)/7 = $5.142

From the numerical calculation, Corleone presents to have a higher $ reward at No.1 and a lower $ at No.2 compared to the regular student's average $. Through that, it presents the high risk and reward from Corleone.

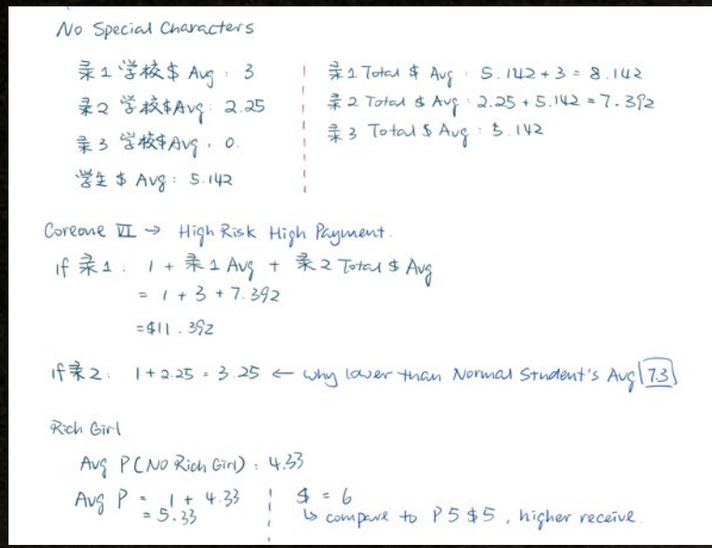


Paris Hiltown

To ensure Hiltown has a balanced AP to $ ratio, calculate the average AP value first and compare it with a regular student with the same AP:

(8+7+6+5+3+3+2+5+0)/9 + 1 = 5.33.

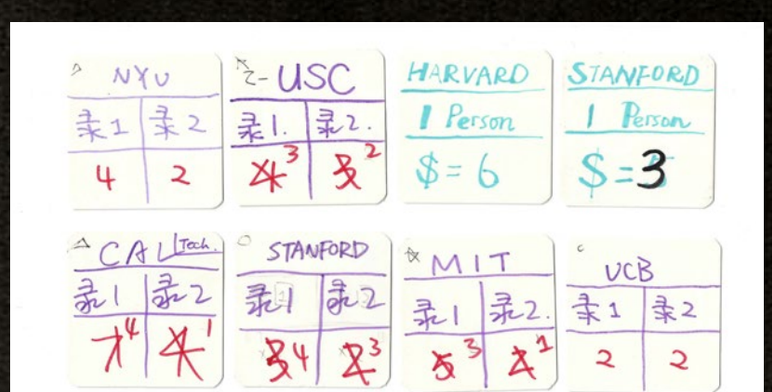
Compared to a regular student with a similar AP value, such as Eesha Kashmir, who values both 5 for her AP and $, having a $ of 6 for Paris Hiltown is reasonable as her AP value is slightly higher than Kashmir while presenting a high risk and reward by betting on this student.



Numerical Calulations

Schools

Among the school cards, there are also 3 special schools whose requirement isn't to accept students with the top 2 highest AP values. Doing so provides more diversity while presenting diverse experiences towards earning $ while playing. Meanwhile, the schools for each round are shown at the beginning of the game so that the players can also start considering their tactics in each round to earn the most $. Meanwhile, these "not so usual" universities provide different categories of students a chance to receive the $, avoiding the possibility that players not receiving any $ in the game.



Student Name	No.1	$	No.2	$
Can-Bridge University	Rank 1 in AP	5	Rank 2 in AP	2
Standfart College	Rank 1 in AP	3	Rank 2 in AP	3
Wall Street College	Rank 1 in AP	3	Rank 2 in AP	1
Yell University	Rank 1 in AP	4	Rank 2 in AP	1
School of Laze	Rank 1 in AP	0	Rank 2 in AP	6
Human Research Center	Rank 1 in AP	3	Rank 5 in AP	2
Juvenile Reform College	Rank 5 in AP	2	Rank 4 in AP	1

Student Name	No.1	$	No.2	$	No.3	$
Wild Goose University	Rank 1 in AP	4	Rank 2 in AP	2	Rank 3 in AP	0

















Settlement

Settlement is one of the most essential part of the game as it determines the winner of the game. Due to the diverse card type and functions, the settlement order primarily affects the final result. Iterations and tests were made to reach the best settlement for players.

The settlement of Instant cards

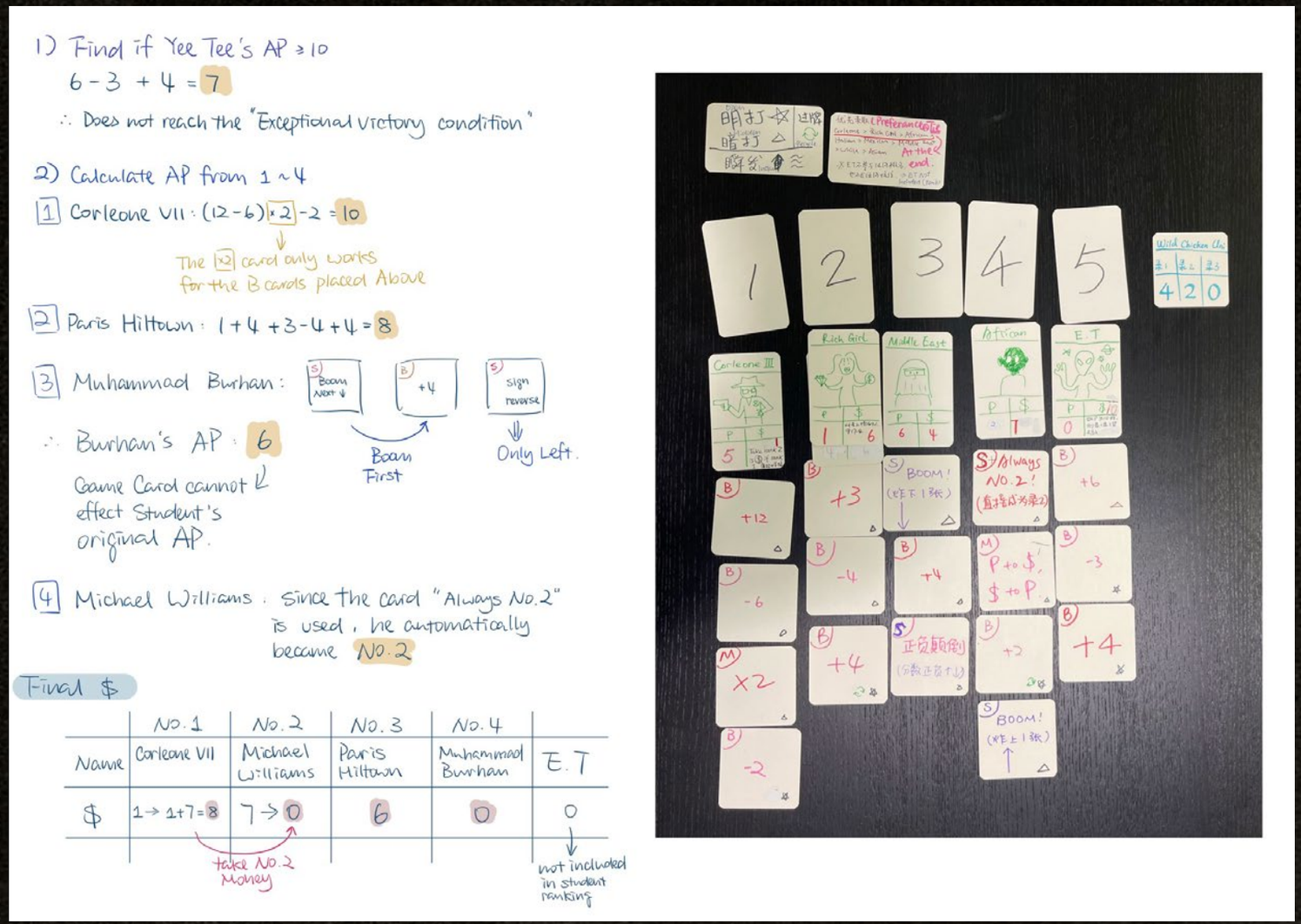
Previously in our gameplay, all instants were left till the settlement round, which was extremely hard. The Instant Cards were removed right after use to reduce the settlement difficulties.

The calculation order

1. "Boom Up"(S) and "Boom Down"(S).
2. "Always No.2"(S) and "Fresh Blood"(S).
3. "Cancel"(M) played as hidden cards.
4. The rest cards settle from top to bottom of the column.

Students

If Yee Tee is present in the round, the players calculate the AP value of Yee Tee first, which reduces extra calculations. If Yee Tee is not placed or does not meet the "exceptional victory condition", calculate from left to right, starting with the student with a card labelled "1".



Culture Context

Corleone VII
Corleone VII is inspired by the two leaders of the Corleone family from the most iconic American crime film series, "The Godfather": they are always fine-dressed and dangerous. In our design, the young successor of the Corleone family needs to "attend a prestigious university" to establish authority and revitalize the family. His "Money robbing skill" is also designed to reinforce the typical behaviors of a Mafia family.

Paris Hiltown
This special character used to call "Rich Girl" in earlier iterations. We wanted to create a young girl who was rich and incompetent. Rich girl's "Ghostwriting" skill was designed as she never does her homework alone. We later named her after the most famous American celebrity, "Paris Hilton" as she fits the most iconic "rich girl" impression and referred to her appearance as Hiltown's character design.

Yee Tee
Initially, we want to design a "troublemaker" with opposite goals to other students to diversify the characters. Then Yee Tee, inspired by the alien of the movie "E.T.," was created. Yee Tee, as an alien creature, comes to Earth isn't for college but to reach her "exceptional victory condition": learn the life of the people on this planet.









Culture Context

General students

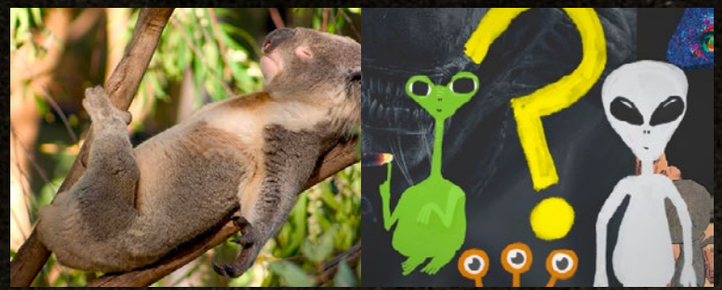
We introduced diverse races to better express U.S. college admissions in real life. The visual design of each race refers to its most representative traits and names to create an immersive atmosphere. Each character is designed with some "stereotypes" as it best represents the race in people's common impression. Though we did not include all races, further races will involve in our later DLCs.

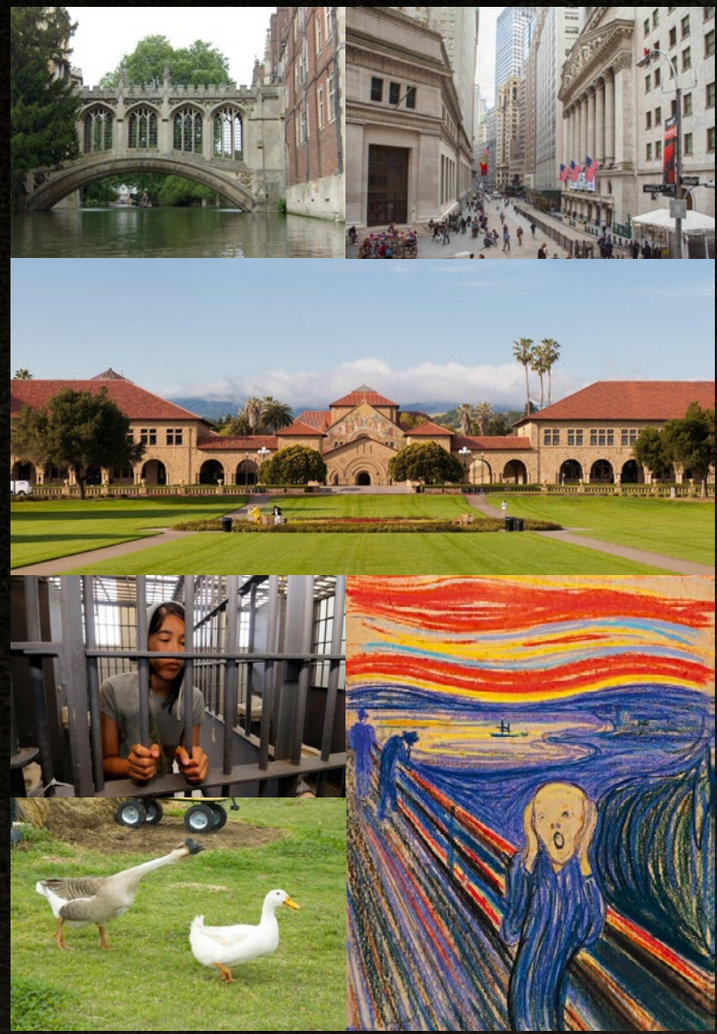


Schools

The design of the school cards provides a funny tone to the players, and they can easily associate the namings with their real-life experiences. The namings of schools were inspired by famous universities and the most representative American culture.

For instance, "Standfart University" and "Can-Bridge University" are inspired by world-class Stanford University and Cambridge University. We intended to create a homonymous name and a funny school logo as the punchline. Moreover, some schools are named based on their unique admission requirements. Schools like "School of Laze" and "Juvenile Reform College" were designed for "academic losers", which prioritised students with poor grades (e.g. accept students with the lowest AP). The design of these "bad schools" led to a greater variety of gameplay and strategies.





Visual Design









Thanks to my teammate Lixue for creating such an excellent visual for the game. Based on our previous visual research on characters, schools, and card skills, she created the entire art set in a minimalist, modern style. We were all delighted with the result of the finished product.

Final Outcome

Click the images to view the introduction video and the gallery of Con-selor.
To find out more information about Con-selor, please visit my website https://catherinet2023.wixsite.com/my-site.











Gameplay Example



Round 1-1
The settlements are all done. One special student on the table, Paris Hilltown, can ask another student to do her homework and boost her AP. The school is also interesting as it will only provide $ to the No.2 student.



Round 1-3
The players started to use the game cards to help the students to boost/drag their AP values. The information isn't much, as many cards are still hidden.



Round 2-1
The preparation stage for round 2 is all set, and two special characters are presenting on stage that will bring the counsellors huge profits and high risks.



Round 1-2
Counselors receive their game cards, and based on their game cards, they need to decide the betting choices carefully and the students to bet to win the most $.



Round 1-4
Round Ends. The card "Always No.2" helps Mariana receive No.2 right away and successfully receive the bonus point given by the school. And YangYang Hu is No.1 but receives no bonuses from the school.



Round 2-2
After fliped over so many cards, only ± 2 cards appear to be open, and these cards could be camouflaged as these points are not very influential.

Gameplay Example



Round 2-3
Counselor C is saving all the powerful Magic and Super cards for the last round for her to turn the table.



Round 3-1
The preparation is all set. Paris Hilton also appears to be on the table as the only special character. But since each counsellor's $ is different, and this is the last round, choices must be made carefully.



Round 3-3
Counselor C cancels Counselor L's exchange card; Counselor L cancels Counselor C's cancel, and Counselor A cancels Counselor L's cancel. The exchange card cannot be used and moved to the discard pile with the cancel cards.



Round 2-4
Using the "twist" card, Mariana's AP changed from -9 to +9, and she received No.1, which changed the students' ranking.

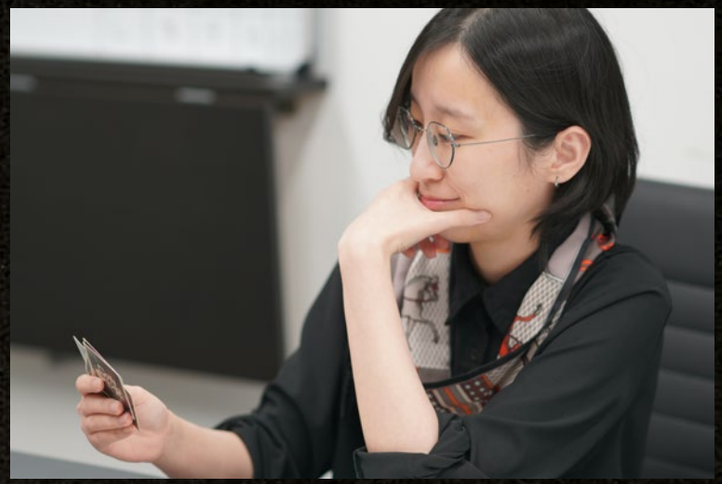


Round 3-2
The players started making their betting choices and tried to observe each other's facial expressions to guess and mislead others' choices.



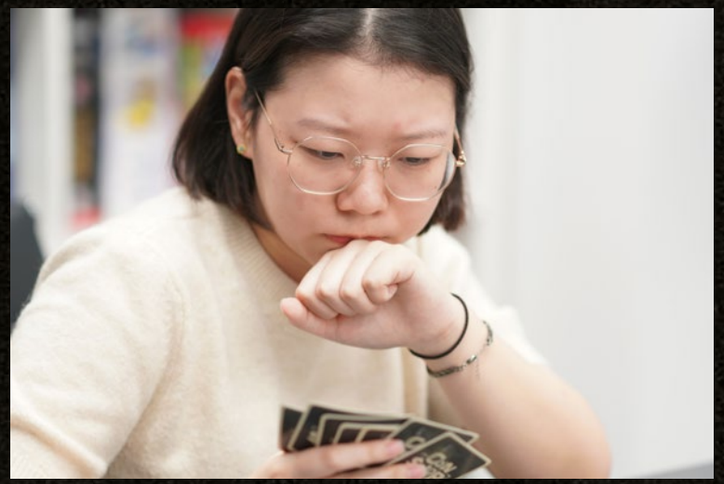
Round 3-4
The game ends by using two very influential Basic cards, "-6" and "-12". Counselor A turns the tide, and both her bet meets the school's requirement.

Players' Review



Counselor A

My experience was fantastic! I can't deny that the 2 Magic Cards I used totally changed my destiny. The Magic Card "Harvest Time" brought me the Basic Card of -6 while the Magic Card "Steal" also helped me to steal Counselor C's "-12", and these two cards turned the tide in the last round! The choices I made are all very conservative. Therefore the $ received are also similar to counselor L. I left all my influential cards to the last round to catch up with counselor C. Eventually, under the use of these two basic cards, the two students I bet all meet the university's requirements, and I receive corresponding $ from the students. I am such a genius!



Counselor C

This game is like riding a roller coaster! I had the most $ in round 1, but it did not cause a big $ gap. Therefore, I chose a conservative double-betting choice to ensure I still received the most bonus. But in Round 2, I observed that Counselors A and L bet on Corleone VII, which I don't. I tried using the Super Card "New Blood" to change Corleone VII, but Counselor L's "Row Bomb" took it out! OMGGGG! I am so angry! And what rages me more is that Counselor A took away my "-12" through the "Steal" card! My life-saving card! Even though I still ranked first in the third round, under the use of "-12" by Counselor A, she had both her betting student meeting the school requirements and eventually surpassed me! I am so sad!



Counselor L

The overall experience I had in this game was okay. In the first round, the student I betted ranked No.1; therefore, I did not receive any bonus from the school as this school provides no $ for No.1, and the second place was taken by Counselor C's "Always No.2" card and received the highest point. I bet Corleone VI in the second round, which is a more conservative choice. Eventually, Corleone got to No.1. Since the AP is tied with Mariana, Mariana gets No.1 due to the preference list, and Corleone is No.2. Therefore, I still cannot catch up with the $ gap. In the third round, I was thinking about single betting on a non-popular student to boost my $, but I didn't have impactful game cards while there was a -12 on the game table, so my students all failed.

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It was never easy to create such a successful game in under four months when we performed over 50 times of game testing. The game brings unique experiences and helps me further understand board game production. As a rookie, I experienced difficulties in reaching a numerically balanced, player-interactive, diverse tactics, components, and well-connected theme game. It requires us to listen to all players' voices carefully and improve, find all the problems in each round, and search for the appropriate solution. I want to present my great thanks to my partner Lixue that supported me all this time and stayed up with me overnight to test the game. Whenever I hear laughter and compliments from players, I feel proud of our work.